

said, I understand why it exists. It ensures every game remains competitive and allows an extra Indian player to feature in the league, which is a positive. Like with the auction and other rules, there are always pros and cons.

One major impact has been on scoring rates, which have statistically increased due to teams having an extra specialist batter. This means no team is ever truly out of a game. You can have a batter at No.8 or even No.9, which allows for aggressive hitting even after losing six or seven wickets. That has changed the way teams approach the back end of an innings.

Strategically, it has added layers to team selection and match planning. The role of all-rounders has also been affected. While having an all-rounder still brings balance, teams can now manage without one if they don't find the right fit.

It's been nearly a year since you stepped down as India's coach on a high, winning the T20 World Cup. Was there a particular moment during the tournament when you felt, "This team is ready to go all the way"?

There wasn't a single moment, but over the last two and a half years, I could clearly see our growth as a white-ball team. We were developing into a real force, and that was reflected not just in the 2023 ODI World Cup and the T20 World Cup, but also in bilateral series and other matches.

Our win-loss percentage over that period was very high, despite rotating a lot of players. The depth in our squad kept improving, and I always felt we would be competitive in any white-ball tournament.

At this point, India is consistently one of the three or four teams that start as favourites in global tournaments. That strength has been building for a while. Even during my time as the India A coach, I saw how much we were progressing in white-ball cricket.

But in these tournaments, you also realise that no matter how strong you are, it often comes down

to one or two crucial games. On any given day, a top side can beat you — just like Australia did in the 2023 ODI World Cup final. They played better cricket and deserved to win.

Going into the T20 World Cup, I knew we were one of the favourites. But I also knew that in knockout games, you're up against teams who are capable of beating you. You prepare as best as you can, but you also need to acknowledge that skill alone isn't always enough.

You need to have depth, resilience, and the ability to handle high-pressure moments. But you also need humility to accept that, in a big final, a bit of luck can play its part too.

You worked with many coaches as a player — John Wright, Greg Chappell, Gary Kirsten. Did any of them influence your approach as a head coach?

Absolutely. Every coach I've worked with has influenced me in some way. You're constantly learning — observing how they operate, how they handle players, and what works in different situations.

In my early years, I had Sandeep Patil and (the late) Aunshuman Gaekwad, followed by Kapil Dev. Later, I worked with John Wright, Greg Chappell, Gary Kirsten, and briefly with Duncan Fletcher. I also spent a lot of time with Paddy Upton in various roles.

You naturally pick up elements from different people, but at the same time, you bring your own approach. Coaching isn't about copying — it's about blending what you've learned with your philosophy and personality. It's a mix of learning from coaches, observing others, and gaining insights through reading and watching.

Each coach had a unique style, and I took valuable lessons from all of them. But ultimately, my approach reflects who I am as a person.

During your coaching stint, you closely followed India's domestic cricket and even made suggestions to improve it. Where do you see the IPL fitting into the overall domestic structure?



The IPL is perfectly placed in the Indian cricket calendar. Before it started, April-May was largely an off-season for Indian cricket. By scheduling T20 matches at night and leveraging the shorter format, the IPL made it possible to play competitive cricket during this period without disrupting the domestic structure.

Unlike other leagues worldwide, which often clash with domestic and Test cricket, the IPL fits seamlessly into India's schedule. It doesn't force players to choose between domestic and franchise cricket, which is a major advantage.

Instead of replacing anything, the IPL has expanded the domestic season. It has also elevated